



YOGTANTRAGAMA
ISSN NO: 2454-888X



April-June 2017

From the Editor in Chief's desk:

By Swami Paranand Tirth

EDITOR IN CHIEF: SWAMI PARANAND TIRTH



Sahasa and mahasahasa .

The penultimate effort to enter the realm of effortlessness has been defined as Anupaya or the absence of all means . The negation of upaya or means does not mean that there is no means but means there can be no means . From a bit grosser perspective let us reflect on asana

or the séance. The means to get established in the asana are lax efforts and absorption in Ananta or the principle of infinity .
(प्रयत्नशैथिल्यमनंतसमापत्तिभ्याम्)

The only effort required here is relaxing all strenuous effort that an aspirant in the beginning puts in . Effortlessness leads to the unison with

your essential nature; the more you strive more strongly do you adhere to the projections of your lower nature . Usually there is an aberrant conception that Shambhava Upaya must be preceded by an assiduous practice of Shakta Upaya; after receiving the anugraha in the form of shaktipata or some other type one can intuitively experience the futility of all efforts or upayas especially when the objective is to seek unison with one's essential nature.

During my sojourn in Kashmir at a secluded cloister one fine morning I woke up with an intuitive insight into the relevance of effort and effortlessness as I recollected Utpala's verse that I had been mugging up previous night

उपायजालं नशिवं प्रकाशयेत्

घटने किं भाति सहस्र दीधितिः

"No means can lead to Parma Shiva, how can a pitcher illuminate the bright sun"

For an aspirant it is very difficult to shred the entanglement of upaya or effort . The impression of cause and effect, actions and their fruition grip the psyche so strongly that one cannot imagine any phenomena as transcending this trail . Very few yogi know that beyond the bahirang limbs of yoga all antarang limbs require effortlessness. **Pratyahar ,Dharana** and **साहस** erroneously defined as inspiration is in fact courageous feat that occurs within an instant . Another meaning of the word is instantaneously the virtue of being **सहसा** . The propitiatory canto of laghustavaa says छिंद्यान्नःसहसा पदैस्त्रिभिरघं may the divine mother shred all our transgressions within a trice.

Any one with some preliminaries of monistic Vedanta can get it more exactly . Time space and substance continuity is within the domain of the superimposed phenomena denoted by a serpent misapprehended instead of a rope . Since all time is within the domain of

Dhyana are rather introverted convergence of awareness which can be had not by exercising ones power of will or action or knowledge but by avoiding all efforts .Beyond this point only faith and devotion or the munificence of the guru is the only impetus.

More you exert more you deviate and at times move in just the opposite direction !

अयमेवहितेबंधःसमाधिमनुतिष्ठसि

Astavakra the rickety hunchback master of king Janak instructs his pupil

"You want to attain samadhi by practice ,this is your bondage ,samadhi or absorption in one's essential nature is innate and spontaneous."

Initiation into this cult of अनुपाय is a great accomplishment, a great break through . After a certain point in the mystic pursuit the advancement becomes like a slow cycling race. To win the race you go the slowest and if by any skill or manoeuvre you can stand still your journey within starts .

Sitting still he dashes far and wide ,Lying quite he pervades everything ,muses the Upanishadic seer *

superimposition the instant of disillusionment which suggests "not a serpent but a rope" doesn't actually exist . So the process of the transition of awareness from the relative to absolute realm is a very subtle and an arcanelly mystic phenomena . This may happen within a plank second and may not happen even in millions of eons . *

• आसीनो व्रजते दूरं शयानो याति सर्वत्रः

Swami Paranand Tirth

Founder president CEO

YTA yoga Tantra and agama(inc)

Editorial



The importance of effort has always been stressed upon and all of us have grown hearing about the significance of hard work but in mystic parlance ‘Effortlessness’ (Sahaja) is considered the most desirable state of being. Often it has been observed the simplest things are most difficult to achieve. We generally tend to complicate our lives so much that we lose touch with the Sahaja bhava residing in us. Result oriented work, which has become the way of working these days gives rise to an anxious mindset responsible for all the chaos we see in the world today.

‘Uselessness’ of art is stressed on precisely because the aspect of being useful connects a thing to the mundane world and its complicated ‘realities’. Immanuel Kant’s ‘Purposiveness without Purpose’, a concept given with regard to judgement of art, probably comes closest to the idea of sahaja. As he points out if the motive of the work of art can be seen clearly then it simply ceases to be art. It becomes one more ‘thing’ around us.

Explaining this idea in a nutshell is the enlightening editorial on ‘Sahasa and Mahasahasa’ by our Guru Swami Paranand Tirthji. Discussing ‘Anupaya’ (Absence of no means) as a coveted path aspired by mystic aspirants Swamiji opines, “Initiation into this cult of अनुपाय is a great accomplishment, a great break through. After a certain point in the mystic pursuit the advancement becomes like a

slow cycling race. To win the race you go the slowest and if by any skill or manoeuvre you can stand still your journey within starts.”

Following this we have another thought provoking write up by Swamiji explaining the importance of ‘eem’ or ‘Kamakala’ beej mantra with respect to 4th Shloka of Laghustava from Pancastavi, a repertoire of coded mystic knowledge. Sublimating of the desiring process in Tantric practices formulates the main idea of the article.

Next we have a detailed introduction to his scholarly book on ‘Rituals of Kashmiri Pandits’ by Dr. Shashishekhar Toshkhani, a versatile expert on Kashmiri art, culture and linguistics. Lamenting the amnesia within the community which has reduced its culture and rituals to acts of token symbolism, he hopes that his work can start an active scholarly discussion on the practices and their significance.

In a similar vein Neeraj Santoshi observes the lack of knowledge of Kashmir Saiva philosophy in its birth place and vanishing of guru shishya parampara which was the bedrock of all Indian philosophical systems. In his encounter with Mark Dyczkowski he sees a real scholar seeker who is trying his best to keep alive the tradition of the great masters of Kashmir Saiva lineage.

Following this we have a short write-up by Geetika Kaw Kher which talks about the creative impulse in Pratyabhijna philosophy

with reference to few verses from Pratyabhijnahrdayam of Ksemaraja.

The final part of Sunder Shridhar's Kailas Mansarovar yatra travelogue in a simple yet subtle manner talks about the bliss felt at the feet of the lord of Kailas and the need to surrender to Him completely to feel the ultimate unison.

We end this issue with a short passage by artist Suva who reflects on the nature of our life expectations and limited consciousness which does not allow us to delve deep in our own hearts.

(Dr.Geetika Kaw Kher is Asst. Professor at Amity School of Fine Arts (ASFA) and teaches History of Art, Aesthetics and Art Criticism)

Emancipation through a refinement of libido drive .

Kamakala : The primordial desire .

Swami Paranand Tirth

यन्नित्ये तव कामराजमपरं मंत्राक्षरं निष्कलं

तत्सारस्वतमित्यवैतिविरलः कश्चित्बुधश्चेद्भुवि

आख्यानं प्रतिपर्वसत्यतपसः यत्कीर्तयंतोद्विजाः

प्रारंभे प्रणास्पदं प्रणयिता नीत्वोच्चरन्ति स्फुटम्

In the arcane lineage of tantricism there is a tradition of encrypting otherwise lofty conceptualisations in aphoristic or discreet syllables called beejakshara.

These are meant to convey the subjective awareness of the master rather than to convey the discursive bulk in a nut shell . Krishna Razdan in his Sanskrit gloss on laghustava says that this mantra is fruitful only when received from a competent guru. The preceptor too should impart the entire mystic knowledge at the time of initiation and not bit by bit.

क् signifies the absolute bliss .ल denotes stability or eternity ,ई the most important syllable of Shri kula is called kamkala and is the encryption of the absolute Brahman . This Kamakala has been enunciated as the subtle personification of the universal mother.

Laghuacharya in the first canto mentions two manifestations of the divine mother inseparable though. Word and meaning are termed as Jyoti and Vak or Bindu and nada. Word precedes meaning in the context of revelations but in a conventional parlance meaning precedes the word. According to the school of Meemamsa Vedic ritualism, word and meaning relation is innate. Tantric schools however fall in with the

school of meemamsakas so far as theorising is concerned.

सचिदानंद

Out of the grandeur of Parmesvara who manifests as existence, consciousness and bliss there emanates Shakti. From her springs forth nada and nada turns into Bindu. The Shakti mentioned here is a priori of nada and bindu or word and meaning.

Grammarians mystics evolved their doctrine on this principle .Shakti is defined by them as the power of consciousness which is the agency that accounts for the word and meaning relationship. Ancient metaphysics attributes the cycle of birth and death to this all pervasive Kamakala.

कामानयः कामयते कामकामी स कामभिर्जायते तत्रतत्र ।

'A desirous man who pursues his desires is accordingly reborn because of his desires. On the other hand a desireless man who has attained completion subsides all his desires in this life only and thus isn't born again.'

It is strange that both bondage and emancipation originate in the desiring part of human psyche. Tantriks however do not begin with gross actions but with what lies at the root of the desiring process i.e. the libido drive. A Freudian libido is an individual drive but a tantrik's concept of the same is a cosmic one. The impetus of सोऽकामयत् (he desired) the creative impulse of the primordial being-besides decreeing the process of universal manifestation also pervades the individual in the form of libido drive.

One of the Upanishads propounds that Kama is the essential nature of this purusa .His cogitation is determined by his innate desire or to put in the verbiage of eastern metaphysics इच्छा जन्याक्रियाभवेत् **'all motivations are determined by desiring process or libido drive'** .अथो खलु काम मयोयंपुरुषः

This was postulated thousand of years before Freud or Jung . While both their theories have been refuted by later scholars who hinted at various limitations this eternal axiom of the Upanishads is universally relevant for ever.

The drive for attaining the ultimate bliss is Paramananda, a refined and sublimate form of libido drive. In the arcane Tantra more emphasis is laid on sublimating this drive rather than on subjugating or transcending it therefore as the implementation of the aforesaid Vedic dictum Tantriks go about it as follows

कामानयःकामयतेकामकामी सकामभिर्जायते
तत्रतत्र त्र्यप्यप्तकामस्यकृतात्मनस्य इहैवसर्वं
प्रविलीयंतेकामाः ।

The mystics evolved a sophisticated system of refining the desiring process

कामेन कामयेत कामी कामं कामेषु योजयेत.

- Instead of focusing on controlling or subjugating this most cardinal impetus of humankind the Tantra aimed at its sublimation. This trend also developed in less conservative Semitic cultures. Refining carnal tendencies which are also produces of lower nature into subtler and refined forms of platonic, divine and spiritual love has been common to most of the mystic paths occidental or oriental. Erore denotes physical and carnal manifestations of the collective as well as the individual libido drive. Erore can be sublimated by stopping the dissipation of Ichha Shakti or the power of will. This requires a reservoir of such power. Ascetics accustomed to a great deal of moderation can help an aspirant by inducing his well refined and thus divine will into the novice.
- This refined "erore" or what the eastern thinkers called विषयांद Converts into vidhyaanand ie philos. Refined Erore becomes Philos or विद्यानंद a comparatively subtler form of ananda. Still more refined aspect is Agape

comparable to aatmanand आत्मानंद .The enlightened seer Yajnavalkya instructs his consort Gargi :

‘ a husband is not loving because he is a husband, he is loving because he is your atman.A wife is not loving because she is a wife but she is loving because she is your atman. Wealth is not dear because it is wealth but it is so because it is atman. Everything is not loving because of it being so. A son is not loving because he is a son but because he is atman. Things are agreeable not because of being a part of the objective phenomenon but because the self is their substratum’.

In a compendium of monistic vedantic-Panchadashi, the author of vidyaaranya has cited these mantras and concluded that it is futile to place the fulcrum of agree ability or priyatah in anything ephemeral except atman the substratum. A canon on eastern metaphysics says .

Priyam tvam rotasyati प्रियंत्वां रोत्स्यतीति .

‘If your notion of agreeability is any where else besides atman that object mistaken as dear will make you cry presumably due to inevitable dissociation’.

It is a Herculean task indeed to channelize and streamline the dissipating "power of will". Since individual efforts do not suffice so the hoary seers of the past invoked compassion of the mother of the universe and sought her munificence through faith devotion and the knowledge of spiritual practices imparted by herself .

Usually the path of action is related with आणवउपाय and that of desire or excercising individual will to शाक्त उपाय .The path of wisdom and spiritual insight comprises शाम्भव उपाय . This present cogitation on kamkala is the path of effort or Shakti . Kundalini is awakened to enhance the pace of spiritual evolution .Awakened kundalini or completely

unfolded awareness alone can give an unalloyed vision of the absolute truth .When she is asleep one is badly caught in the quagmire of reciprocating objectivity, at times upto the extent of complete oblivion of one's essential nature .Hence there is so much stress in the agama on the subservience to the preceptor and observance of the kulacharas or the esoteric precepts .

An aspirant who learns the knack of accumulating and orientating the individual willpower syncing it with the cosmic one is liberated from the fetters of incessant birth and death ,otherwise it is impossible even to believe in the possibility of any such occurrence let alone seeking deliverance from.

There is maxim among Vedic scholars that all Vedas emanate from the eternal word or Omkara and subside into it .The primordial word of god also pervades all human expressions specially if it follows the order of manifestation into the audible speech as per the mystic canons . The primordial word becomes three fold as the three modes of vak and then eight fold comprising eight groups of Sanskrit alphabet . The vak as the mystic canons say mixes up with the fire of consciousness and vital spirit and assumes grosser forms of conceivable ideas and expressible utterances.

"Just as a leaf is pervaded by veins so is the entire vak pervaded by Omkara*.

This has been the most meticulously conceived arduously practised and ritualistically propagated holy syllable of the Hindus .

*If one recites Vedas not preceded by Omkara and not followed by it ,it goes waste . Each Veda has its own version of Omkara .Rikveda for instance has त्रैस्वर्य उदात्(with three connotations) that is why they put a mark of three between O and M (ओ३म्) . Yajurvedic omkara is called उदात्तानुदात्स्वरितः (contains all three letters which are required to be pronounced with उदात्तअनुदात्त and स्वरित connotations). Omkar of the Samveda is called

दीर्घप्लुतोदात्त with triple long connotation . Atharva Vedic Omkar is merely the fourteenth vowel with nasal accent I.e.ओं or ओम् ,

The viva voce tradition of Vedic recital is left with only a few unalloyed branches or shakhas . This canto has some clues about a branch of rikveda in which instead of Omkara the reciter pronounced eenkar before the commencement of Vedic recital. This arcane syllable is a coveted knack of streamlining the awareness among the votaries of tantrikism . Some mystics claim it's origin in the Asyavam suktam of the rikveda .

This canto of laghustava says that the twice borns recite it like Omkara but owing to its subtlety and mystic import this is rather the fourth matra of Omkara which cannot be pronounced phonetically ,instead it pervades all the three components of Omkara if pronounced with due precision .

This has also been called as the fourth matra or arch matra of Omkara which as durgasaptashati puts it is यानुच्चार्या वि शेषतः which is '**remains un pronounced but resonates spontaneously.**'

Another mystic phonetic coincidence is regarding the elimination of its preceding and following portions namely क and ल both guttural and labial palatial syllables which require some effort and stress in their pronunciation where as the fourth vowel with nasal resonates spontaneously . There is a belief among the orthodox votaries of the eternal and living word that it stands in no need of any effort of pronunciation .निरपेक्ष रवः is one of the attributes of the Vedas, the eternal word that resonates without any effort of pronunciation .

For this time continuum to be consistent the word must be beginning less and thus end less .To be beginning less is a must for an entity to be endless but vice versa may not be consistent . Beginningless entity may have an end . The word as the noted grammarian mystic

Bhartrihari propounds in his vakyapadiyam (a compendium of word and sentence) is beginning less as well as endless

अनादिनिधनं ब्रह्म शब्दतत्त्वं यदक्षरम्

This obviously signifies the primordial consciousness as conditioned in Shabd or Shabda brahm.

One famous hymn to the goddess Durga goes as follows

सुधा त्वमक्षरे नित्ये त्रिधामात्रात्मिकास्थिता

अर्धमात्रात्मिकानित्या या निच्चार्या विशेषतः ।(Durga saptashati)

'O imperishable one thou manifest in the form of the three portions of Omkara and also manifest as the half matra which cannot be pronounced through any effort of the vocal chamber '.

There are two forms of Omkara says one arcane interpretation of the fourth quarter of the famous Gayatri mantra (this turya Gayatri has been mentioned in the first or second Agni of Kathaka Brahman most of which is now obsolete .) the first form is सवद or pronounceable where as the second one is अवदः not pronounceable . The former has a beginning and therefore an end since it didn't exist before pronunciation and lasts when the pronunciation ends . The latter non pronounceable and latent mystic syllable is the a synthesis of nada and Bindu and is usually referred to as kamakala .The version of kamakala in this canto has no ka and la . This fourth vowel,of Sanskrit alphabet has been highly spoken off in many prominent tantras and agamas .

Prithvidharacharya one of the prominent disciples of Adishankara in his hymn to bhuvaneshwari says

आदिक्षांतविलासलालसतया तासातुरीया तु या

क्रोडीकृत्य जगत्त्रंविजयते। वेदादिविद्यामयी

तां वाचं मयिसंप्रसादय सुधाकल्लोलकोलाहल

क्रीडाकर्णनवर्णनीयकवितासाम्राज्यसिद्धिप्रदा

(Bhuvaneshwari

satva)

(In the process of manifesting as letters from a to ksha the fourth Vowel is eem may it be victorious as it contains all three realms in its lap. The fourth vowel I.e. Eem is the manifestation of vak containing all learnings like the Veda etc. O mother cultivate that eloquence and poesy in me which culminates into the empire of epical composition with all rhetorics ,similes metaphors and alliteration)

The power of consciousness manifests in the form of fifty odd syllables. Among them the fourth vowel is ever victorious she manifests in the form of all eighteen faculties of scholarship and all three realms are situated in her lap . Kamakala or turban as it is called in the mystic canons ,has the entire syllabus of ancient traditional studies nascent in her womb, but this lineage is highly arcane and the author says if any wise man is present upon the earth only he can know that this is a key to great erudition .

There have been prodigies of extraordinary erudition who received this mantra from competent preceptors . This syllable as Prithvadaracharya puts it in his hymn to Bhuvaneshwari has all areas of human learning encrypted in it , so an adept can induce all his learning into a novice through this syllable . There have been instances in the history of Sanskrit scholarship rare though ,when a novice shared all the learning of his preceptor within no time . There have been instances when a small baby began to suckle the toe of a great Saint as a child's prank and began to compose flawless complicated Sanskrit verses. A student was blessed that he will memorise all holy books he saw at a library and he actually did .The famous pundit is still remembered in Kashi as a genius who had memorised thousand scriptures. ,Another yogi put both his hands on a dunce child's head and he became an eloquent scholar . The famous grammarian Nagesh Bhatt was a retarded lad who was blessed by a yogi through shaktipat and he became one of the most authentic figures in the area of Panini's descriptive linguistics . Adi Shankaracharya's redemption of Totaka a ten year old retarded child through shaktipat is famous among the votaries of his monism. All this happens

through an induction of this formula of streamlining human awareness . Laghu acharya the author of this hymns says that arcane phenomena is evident only to rare yogins who belong to this cult .

In the tantrik canons Kamakala has been semiotically described as a lady draped in green and carrying an ear of corn crouched on bare earth . This may be a symbolic depiction of the all pervading consciousness who besides being an agency of all cognitive and volitional faculties also accounts for the process of germination and vegetative reproduction .

Ancient hoary seers may have foreseen the future eco imbalance and attributed the essential measures to this aspect of nature . She can be revived as an archaic goddess of fertility and eco awareness . This Indian version of ancient Mesopotamian and Sumerian goddess of fertility is still adored by many aspirants who are initiated into this cult

इत्थं कामकलात्मिकां भगवतीमंतःसमाराधयन्

आनंदांबुधिमज्जनं प्रलभतां मनंथुं सज्जनः (Tripura Sundari Manaspuja)

'In this manner by adoring the goddess Kamakala within themselves

A decent aspirant should submerge into the ocean of ascetic rapture and attain the supreme bliss'

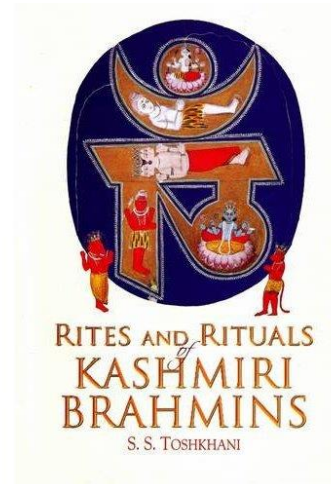




A Perspectival Look at the 'Rites and Rituals of Kashmiri Brahmins'

Dr. S. S. Toshkhani

Passionately drawn towards exploring aspects of Kashmir's cultural and intellectual traditions though I was from the beginning, I was not particularly inclined towards venturing into an area like rituals and rites. Rituals, I must confess, were anathema to me as I considered them to be nothing more than superfluous outer ceremony which had nothing or little to do with religious life in the deeper sense. So when UNESCO scholar, Prof. B. N. Saraswati chose the subject of rituals and ritual arts of Kashmiri Hindus for me to work on as a research project for the Janapada Sampada department of IGNCA during a brief meeting I had with him in early 2002, I did not know what to say. He was heading that department at that time and was a social anthropologist of eminence. Rituals, he explained noticing my discomfiture, were one of the bonds that existed between the Hindu community of Kashmir and the cultural life of Hindus of the country at large, and should not be understood in a narrow sense. They give you a sense of identity. I saw his point, but how to proceed on a subject you have been holding in contempt all your life. Kashmir was sort of out of bonds for any scholarly work of the nature I had been assigned to take up. And mass exodus of Kashmiri Pandits from there in wake of terrorist violence had complicated things. They had been



uprooted and were in a state of dispersal. How could I witness a Hindu ritual performance in its traditional form outside their eco-cultural habitat? I knew that scholars from different parts of the world had been showing a growing interest in the study of Hindu, and particularly Vedic, ritual. But nobody had taken up Kashmiri Hindu religious activity as a separate field of scholastic inquiry. This was perhaps because they could not see any perceptible difference between the ritual system they had adopted and that which Hindus in general followed. The pan-Indian elements were all there, but there were also some remarkable variations and modifications because of *deshāchāra* which could not be ignored. Characteristically Kashmiri ritual system had elements which had to be identified and analysed while dwelling on the commonalities. Hardly anything systematic had been done in this direction by the religious historian and social anthropologist, Indian or Western.

As I decided to start my study in right earnest, I understood if I had to work on regional peculiarities of the ritual traditions and practices of the Kashmiri Brahmins, I had to comprehend the “formative consciousness” and epistemological matrixes from which they had sprung. I had to forge my own methodological and conceptual tools, I thought, and that meant adopting an approach involving study of related textual material as well as field work. This

called for having discussions with available ritual experts and resource persons and there were hardly any around either in Delhi or in Jammu for any worthwhile discussions about regional peculiarities regional peculiarities of the ritual traditions and practices of the Kashmiri Brahmins. The last of the greatest amongst them Pandit Raghunath Kulkiloo had passed away some years ago, but Pandit Kashinath Handoo was there. The related texts too had to be obtained. I sought the help of Prof. Bansi Lal Fotedar and it was he who came to my rescue. Interviews with Pandit Handoo and some other scholars who were still in the field were arranged. That proved of some help, at least I was able to clear doubts on some points about which I was yet vague in my mind. Not a real breakthrough though as many who were thought to be knowledgeable about things did not exactly prove to be so. Just at that time I read Fritz Staal, a German expert on Vedic fire ritual and found him saying that "Asian rituals are rituals without a religion", creating doubts about meaning of ritual itself. "Rites become religious" he has written, "when they are provided with religious interpretation". At the same time he has emphasised that ritual traditions have social significance in that they identify groups and distinguish them from each other. It now became necessary to arrive at a basic line of approach to the question of what actually constituted Hindu religious ritual and what could be defined as variation and deviation at the regional level. Did rituals really have any meaning and how did they help in defining identity?

I noted in this context that Richard H. Davis, another eminent Western scholar, but of medieval Shaiva ritual, is highly critical of such scholars who tend to "characteristically present Indian rituals as instances of highly elaborate routinized behaviour, ignoring the philosophical foundations on which they are based". A focus now emerged for my study and I found it found it possible to move ahead. In the new light in which I began see my subject now I came to understand rituals as established patterns of religious activity embedded in the cultural

consciousness of a people, even as they seek to link mundane or natural reality with the divine or trans-natural. They combine in their structure mental, physical and verbal actions which achieve a symbolical character giving the whole a meaning and significance through "invocation of the sacred and the transcendent" beyond what any natural process can give it. As Prof. Daya Krishna has pointed out, rituals transform the biological cycle into a cultural cycle. That is why, he explains, "... In all cultures birth and death are not just biological phenomena but profound cultural events associated with a lot of ritual and ceremonies which transform the biological into the cultural". The ritual processes that set into motion this transformation of the natural or causal are closely related to the attitude of a civilization to time and space and their sacralisation and symbolization.

Viewing things in the Indian context it can be said about rites or rituals that they are intertwined throughout with human life and human activity, beginning with the birth of an individual or even earlier with conception, and continuing through crucial stages of his or her life up to his or her death. Collectively, they are called *samskāras*. Apart from these passage of time or life- cycle rituals, there are ceremonies related to different forms of worship in which the blessings of gods / goddesses are invoked for fulfillment of worldly desires or for spiritual enlightenment. These worship rituals, commonly known as *pūjā* may externally vary in some respects from place to place or in different social milieus, but they have the same basic internal structure.

Whether seen as encoded processes of change or expressions of reverence for the sacred, the fundamental ritual activities prevalent among Kashmiri Hindus, as among other Hindu communities of the country, can be broadly classified under the following heads: (1) *Samskāras* or life-cycle (passage of time) rituals and other domestic ceremonies, (2) *Pūjā* or worship services, (3) Tantric practices and (4) Ritual arts. Eminent ritual

expert Jayant Burde has divided religious rituals into these four categories: worship rituals, rites of passage, festive rituals and sacraments. According to Nusahi Tachikawa and Shaon Hino, religious activity can be divided into two kinds: (1) That which takes as its goal the spiritual well-being of the individual, and (2) that which has the purpose of enabling the group or the society to operate smoothly (festivals, initiation rites etc.). Following these two noted Japanese scholars of Indian rituals, it was the study of *samskāras* or life-cycle rituals of Kashmiri Hindus that I took up first, as these for the common people form the core of religious activity, and then the *pūjā* rituals. In both cases, as I noted, rituals serve as means of communicating with divine beings or trans-natural powers that are believed to guide and influence the course of human actions. While benevolent and favourable influences are sought to be attracted and appeased, as Dr. Rajbali Pandey has pointed out, ritual devices are used to ward off or banish harmful and hostile influences (evil and uncanny spirits, goblins, demons etc.), often by invoking the help of deities and gods. In fact, ritual practices all over the world follow a similar pattern – purification, banishment, propitiation and consecration.

After these general characteristics that rituals display, I went on to describe the constituent elements of the rites and rituals of Kashmiri Hindus in accordance with the analysis provided by the pioneering expert of Hindu *samskāras*, Dr. Rajbali Pandey. Agni or fire is the first and most sacred of these components, an *dis* being worshipped as the presiding deity of sacrifices and domestic rites and ceremonies since the Vedic times -- *agnim īde purohitam*. Fire purifies, consecrates and acts as a protector and witness to human intent. Offerings are made into fire and through it to the gods in almost every ritual performance. Kashmiris burn bdellium and sesame seeds in a *kāngrī* during weddings and other ceremonies for auspiciousness and to banish evil spirits. Water, a symbol of life itself, is the next important constituent for its purifying effects and powers

to remove contamination. Bathing, especially in sacred rivers, sipping water (*āchamana*), and lustration or sprinkling of water are believed to be means of removing physical as well as spiritual impurities.

Prayers, appeals and blessings are another class of constituents that can be placed next on the list. Prayer, says the eminent philosopher Prof. Daya Krishna, “seeks the intervention of the transcendent in the normal processes that are supposed to be governed by causality”. Prayers for success, health, long life, happiness, obtaining children, material prosperity, spiritual salvation etc. are a common feature of Kashmiri Hindu rituals, as also seeking of blessings of gods, elders, preceptors and teachers, spiritual personalities etc.

Offering sacrificial food and presents to propitiate and please gods and supernatural beings is another major constituent of rituals including those performed by Kashmiri Hindus. Special occasions and festivals have been set apart in sacred texts to invite, placate and feast them in the hope of obtaining their favours. As we know, apart from oblations of barley, rice, sesame seeds, dried fruits, molasses, sugar candy, clarified butter or ghee, milk etc. at *yajñas* and *havans*, the most common food offering to gods made by Kashmiri Hindus is *tāhrī* or rice flavoured with turmeric powder and ghee or oil. Sacrificial food like *khicharī* and fish and rice is offered to appease Kubera, the Lord of Yakshas and the *Grihadevatā* (Kashmiri *gardivtā*) or the Deity of the House, while meat offerings are made to deities like Bhairava, Kālī, Jwālā, and Tripurā. Lambs are also slaughtered to please certain deities with animal sacrifice, though such practices have now become rare.

Like their co-religionists elsewhere in the country, Kashmiri Hindus attach great significance to orientation or direction the performer should take while performing a ritual act. Direction of movement in domestic and other rituals is clearly specified in the religious texts they follow. Citing Gobhila’s *Grihyasūtra*,

Veena Dass observes: "...The right side has precedence over the left in rituals to mark the passage of time, as in the morning and evening oblations to be made to the fire on the advent of the new moon and full moon". She further writes: "Similarly, in all rites of transition except death the use of the right side is prescribed." The opposition between right and left, she explains, "is clearly associated with 'rites to gods' and 'rites to ancestors', the former being associated with propitiation of divine beings who are friendly and benevolent, the latter being associated with those supernatural beings who have to be appeased, who inspire terror and have the potential of causing great harm if they are not regularly propitiated." This applies fully to the domestic rites of Kashmiri Hindus as well, though they follow the directions given in different texts. Following Indian mythology, they too consider south to be the direction of Yama, the god of Death, and hence inauspicious. In all rites performed by them the subject faces the east, which is associated with light and warmth, and therefore "happiness and glory".

Observance of taboos on is yet another feature that marks the ritual behaviour of Hindus of Kashmir. These are associated with circumstances like pregnancy, childbirth, adolescence, marriage and death and are related to purity and impurity (*shauch-ashauch*, auspicious-inauspicious (*shubha-ashubha*) or else to warding off evil influences and the evil eye and other possible dangers. Then there are taboos associated with certain months or days which are believed to be inauspicious and when certain things should not be done. There are also minor taboos connected with food which are followed mainly from protecting a person from evil influence or impurity which may be physical, moral or spiritual. Fasting, abstaining from taking non-vegetarian food on particular days or occasions and notions of purity and impurity in cooking, prohibition or prescription of particular type of food – these are also included in the kind of taboos that the so-called orthodox among Kashmiri Pandits observe.

Divinatory methods, based on the belief that gods indicate what is to come in the future through the medium of natural phenomena and other agencies, too have an important place in the pattern of ritualistic behaviour of the Kashmiri Pandits. Besides liturgical utterances and acts, gods are sought to be pleased in their rituals through song and dance which are believed to evoke generosity and benevolence from them in the form of material prosperity, success and protection from misfortunes as well as for bringing in auspiciousness.

After these general observations, arose the question of accessing the particular ritual texts which provide the parameters for the Kashmiri Hindus to follow in their ritualistic behaviour. Foremost among these is the *Grihyasūtra* of Laugakshi. I had heard about Laugakshi but his name was only a faint echo in my ears. He had written his *Grihyasūtra* for adherents of the Kāthaka school of Krishna Yajurveda to which Kashmiri Brahmins belong. But to obtain an insight into its ordainments also to know to what extent they were practically followed by the Pandits required that the text be studied seriously. Though listed among the important *grihyasūtras*, the Laugakshi *Grihyasūtra* is not a much commented upon text. I learnt, the rules and regulations laid down by Laugakshi Muni alone are regarded by the Kashmir Pandits as the true norm and source of their *āchāra*, no other *grihyasūtra* being used in Kashmir for guidance in performance of rituals and rites. Can anyone beat it --the Pandits follow Laugakshi's ordainments but know nothing about him or about the Kāthaka school to which they belong. To excavate the facts I buried myself in Laugakshi's text, photocopies of which were very kindly provided to me by well known scholar and author Dr. Rames Taimiri. For this I shall ever remain thankful to him. I managed to make some headway, but there was a whole host of *grihyasūtras* followed in India -- those written by Āshvalāyana, Gobhila, Āpastamba, Pāraskara, Hiranyakeshī, Mānava for instance. I had to acquaint myself about them too and their peculiarities for a proper understanding of

Laugakshi's text and context. It was a stupendous task but all the same important to undertake as no Western or Indian scholar had cred to render it into English nor an Indian language with the exception of W. Caland who has written some notes and comments on it in English.

When exactly did Laugakshi live and when did the vast *grihyasūtra* literature come to be composed? Scholars as usual do not agree, but if Veena Das is to be believed, the *grihyasūtra* literature was composed sometime between c. 500 – 200 BCE, and that is the date we can ascribe to our Laugakshi also. The Vedic elements with which his *Grihyasūtras* are replete seem to confirm this. The text of the *Grihyasūtra* was brought out in two volumes under the Kashmir Sanskrit Texts Series by Jammu and Kashmir Research and Publications Department in 1928 and 1934 respectively. It was critically edited by Pandit Madhusudan Kaul Shastri who wrote a very valuable Introduction to the first volume giving preliminary information about the work, the author and the commentator Devapala. Pandit madhusudan Kaul had promised to write a detailed introduction to the second volume as well but did not do so. According to him Aditya Darshana wrote a *vivarna* on it while the *Paddhati* was written by Brahmanbala and *bhāshyam* by Devapala. Devapala's commentary, Pandit Madhusudan Kaul tells us, has been incorporated in the text but in a way that it is difficult to distinguish between the two. The Italian scholar Dr. Caland had also critically edited Laugakshi's *Grihyasūtras* with extracts from the three commentaries and addition of appendixes and indexes. I found the commentary useful at places but I also took the help of *Shatpatha Brāhmaṇa* and several other primary and secondary sources to have a better understanding of things.

But while the rites and rituals of Kashmiri Brahmins are primarily anchored in the *Laugakshi Grihyasūtra*, there are also various phases through which they have passed in terms of their historical development as

reflected in other sources of inquiry like the Nilamata Purana and Bhṛṅgisha Samhita. And if Laugakshi's *Grihyasūtra* form the Vedic substratum of the ritual system of the Kashmiri Hindus, the latter texts represent a stage when this substratum was overlaid by elements of Puranic and Tantric modes of worship. By the time of the Nilamata Purana, a 6th century text which gives Kashmir's own creation myth, the Vedic fire sacrifice (*yajña*) was replaced by practices like *vrata* (observance of religious vows), *dāna* (charity), *japa* (repetition of the deity's name), *utsava* (festivals), *tīrthayātrā* (pilgrimage), *pūjā* (individual or collective worship of iconic deities), *upavāsa* (fasts) etc. A significant feature of religion in the Nilamata era was the emergence of a whole new pantheon of gods and goddesses, mostly of local origin, who could be invoked through their anthropomorphic images. Thus, besides the worship of the five major Puranic deities, viz. Brahma, Vishnu, Shiva, Durga, Ganesha in their various manifestations and Surya the Sun god, the Nāga deities, the deities of the Pañcharātra and the Bhāgvata cults, Kubera, even Buddha, Vitasta and many other river goddesses and deities of local origin found their place in the religious belief system.

The ever joyful and sportive people of the era who tried to live in perfect harmony with the beautiful natural environs of the Valley, celebrating festivals galore. In spite of a religious veneer, many of their festivals like *Krishyārambha*, *Yāvagrāyana*, *Navānna-vidhāna*, *Shyāmādevī Pūjana*, *Irāmañjarī Pūjā*, *Navasamavatsara*

Mahotsava, *Navahimāpātotsava* and the *vratas* of

Uttarāyana and *Dakshināyana* were actually related to agriculture and the cycle of seasons. Some of these festivals such as the *Navasamvatsara*

Mahotsava (*Navareh*) and *Navahimāpātootsava* (*Navashīn*) continue to be celebrated to this day. Festivals

like *Irāmañjarī Pūjana* and *Shrāvanī Utsava* show the kind of catholic and liberal values the

society of the times cherished and the freedom that women enjoyed. On the *Irāmañjarī Pūjana*, men and women were urged to visit gardens and parks and adorn each other with garlands of the *Irāmañjarī* flowers, while on the *Shrāvanī* festival young maidens are asked to enjoy water sports. *Sukhasaptikā*, which was perhaps the same as Diwali, was a festival dedicated to Kāmadeva, the god of Love.

Nilamata also describes in detail a number of places of ancient pilgrimage, mentioning their legends and significance. These include Amareshwara or Amarnath, Kapalamochana and other *tirthas* which continue to be places of pilgrimage even now. Nilamta is not ritual text as such, but a lot of information about rituals performed in that age can be gleaned from it. There is also a clear thrust towards folk religious practices in this personal *purāna* of Kashmiri Hindus.

More valuable from the ritualistic point of view is the Bhṛingīsha Samhitā which incorporates various *tīrtha mahātmyas* or glorification of sacred sites and sheds valuable light on the sacred geography of Kashmir. Though the exact date of the Samhitā is difficult to determine, Dr. Yashpal Khajuria, who has edited its Shri Ranbir Singh Research Institute edition, is of the view that it must have been composed sometime between the 5th century and 12th century of the Vikrami Era, though it is also possible that some portions of it may have been incorporated much later. The name of the sage Bhṛingīsha, to whom it is ascribed, is associated with ancient sages like Kashyapa and Shandilya. The text marks for the first time the dominance of Shaivāgamic and Shākta cults in the religious life of the Kashmiris as reflected in the its glorification of the sacred sites dedicated to various deities worshipped in Kashmir. Beginning with Tulmul, where the famous shrine dedicated to Mahārājñī, popularly pronounced as Mahārāgñyā, or Khīr Bhavānī is located, the Bhṛingīsha Samhitā (BS) goes on to describe the significance of the shrines of Sharikā, Jwālā, Jyeshthā, Shāradā and other manifestations of the Mother Goddess together

with their legends, mantras, hymns, and modes of worship. What assumes great importance in this context is that some scholars are trying to deny any antiquity to two of the most popular local goddesses Rāgñyā and Sharika, in particular the former who they argue came into existence only recently. How did the worship of a “Vaishnavite” goddess who is offered only vegetarian offerings like milk, sugar candy, *khīr* etc. come to gain such tremendous popularity among by Kashmiri Pandits after the advent of Dogra rule only, they ask. Claiming that she is a creation of the Dogra rulers who were followers of Vishnu by faith, and therefore vegetarian, they argue that a vegetarian goddess is incompatible with the traditions of Tantric Kashmir and cannot otherwise be explained except an anachronism. They also refer to the legend given in the Samhitā in the section titled *Shrī Rājñī Prādurbhāva* about the goddess having been brought from Lanka by Hanumana to prove their point. An example of such logic can be seen in the recently published book ‘A Goddess is Born: The Emergence of Khir Bhawani in Kashmir’ written by Madhu Bazaz Wangu. What such scholars forget, and they include T. N. Madan, a sociologist of international repute, is that there are several historical references to Tulmul as a place of pilgrimage, besides the fact that it was the well-known mystic saint Krishna Joo Kar, a great devotee of the Mother Goddess, who rediscovered and demarcated the area of the sacred spring in which the image of the goddess is installed and lived in the 17th century in the time of Aurangzeb. The present temple was constructed there no doubt by Maharaja Pratap Singh in the year 1920, but before that a 10th century idol stood there under a mulberry tree which was in place there when Swami Vivekananda made a pilgrimage to the shrine in 1898. (It may be noted that the word *tul* in Kashmiri means mulberry.) These scholars also fail to note that Bhavani means the consort of Bhava, a name of Shiva and that she is represented with all the iconography of Durga. Furthermore, devotion to Vishnu was an equally dominant feature of Kashmiri religious life along with Shaivism and Shaktism. The

Nilamata Purana shows a clear tilt towards Vaishnavism and scholars say that cults like the Pañcharātra had taken their birth there. Apart from that, amalgamation of two goddesses into one can be seen in Sharada, the goddess of speech and learning, also who is shown seated on a lion indicating Saraswati and Durgā merging into one.

The glorification of the shrine of Shārikā Parrvata (modern Hari Parbat) is described in much greater detail in BS, covering six *pāṭalas* or sections. Linking it with the creation myth of Kashmir, the sacred text narrates how the Great Goddess Durgā herself took the form of a *shārikā* or starling to deliver the land from the terror of the demon Baka and crushed him under a peak of Mount Sumeru which she was carrying as a pebble in her beak, BS also tells us about the various deities that occupy various places along the entire periphery of the sacred hill. It is through the *Samhitā* we come to know that the Goddess Sharikā is to be worshipped in the form of a natural *Shrīchakra* inscribed on the main rock that represents her and that this rock is to be smeared with vermilion and ghee. It also describes the offerings that are to be made to her on different days of the week and ways for circumambulation of the sacred hill. The *dhyāna shloka* of the goddess given in BS shows Sharikā carrying among other things a ploughshare in one of her eighteen hands which Durgā. Does this indicate that she was originally an agricultural goddess who was later identified with Durgā herself.

Among the numerous other sacred sites of Kashmir whose spiritual significance BS celebrates are Amarnath and the sacred stops that fall en route, Harmukh and Gangabal, Kapalmochan, Martanda, Pushkara, Sangam etc. The rituals and ceremonies associated with them represent a period in the religious history of Kashmir when the temple and places of pilgrimage had become centres of group religious activities for Hindus. An interesting feature of the work is that quite a number of the pilgrimage places of Kashmir it describes are named after well-known Hindu pilgrimage

centres of India like Ganga, Godavari, Prayag, Kurukshetra, Pushkar etc. This is so not just because the *tīrthas* in mainland India were inaccessible in the winters to the common man because of excessive snowfall, but because of the deep reverence for these centres in the Kashmiri Hindu psyche. That is perhaps the reason that almost every sacred river is given the appellation of Ganga by them – Dūdḥ Gangā, Nila Gangā, Kishengangā, etc. Another important aspect that I have highlighted is that in the local sacred texts like Nilamata Purana and BS we find chanting of Vedic mantras juxtaposed with Puranic hymns and Tantric mantras and ritual practices. This makes it obvious that while the Vedic elements continued to play an anchoring role, Puranic and Tantric liturgy had come to be regarded as the established norm in the ritualistic behaviour of Kashmiri Hindus. In fact the juxtaposition of all the three elements continues to constitute the core of their religious life down to the present times. This shows Kashmiri hindu rituals having a three tiered structure – Vedic, Puranic and Tantri.c

Apart from the glorification of places of pilgrimage, significance of important festivals and celebrations of Kashmiri Hindus, like *Shivarātri*, *Navavarshotsava* or *Navreh* and a number of other religious celebrations with their exclusively Kashmiri features I also forms a substantial part of the BS. About these I will discuss a little later, but suffice it to say here that this raises the question of the essential nature of these festivals underlining as it does that festivals and *yātrās* are related to civilizational memory. The celebration of “foundational festivals” can be seen as enactment and re-enactment of cultural events supposed to have occurred in the remote past. They are related to civilizational memory and, as Prof. Daya Krishna has pointed out, are internalized to “such a degree that a person finds his identity in participating in them” and even feels “that a very important part of himself would be missing if he does not do so”. While the cycle of festivals points to their relationship with civilizational memory in time, the notion

of pilgrimages to places deemed to be sacred is linked with “the spread of memory to space”. This notion of a journey to these places that an individual would like to undertake sometime, as Prof. Daya Krishna points out, consists of the feeling that by doing so “he becomes a part of something larger than himself and through which he achieves a personal identity at a deeper level of his being”.

I also consider it necessary to mention here that Tantric modes of worship and ritual practices of esoteric cults came to occupy the centre-stage in the religion practiced in Kashmir from the 7th century onwards and with an extensive body of sacred texts, known as the Bhairava Tantras, exerted a pervading influence on the Kashmiri Hindu mind. These included the Rudra Yāmala Tantra, Malini Vijaya Tantra, Svachchanda Tantra, Netrta Tantra, Mrigendra Tantra, Vamakeshvara Tantra and Yogini Tantra among various others. The schools of Agamic Shaivism like Krama, Kula and Trika gained fast popularity and a dominant position when in the 10th – 11th century the great Abhinavagupta synthesized them under one exegetical scheme as monistic Shaivism in his monumental work, the *Tantraloka*, interiorizing their rites and rituals. According to Navjivan Rastogi it is the most comprehensive and important single source of information about the various aspects of Shaiva ritual with *mantra*, *mudrā*, *nyāsa*, *mandala*, *dīkshā*, *charyā*, *upāsana* and *yāga* as its constituents. It also deals with the *nitya karma* or daily rites and *naimittika karma* or occasional rites as also with *antyeshti* or funerary rites and *shrāddha* or post-funerary rites which are performed by the little known sect of *Shivakarmī*. The latter are actually practitioners of rituals of non-dual Shaivism of Kashmir. These rituals are very lengthy, elaborate and complicated, consisting of a series of *pūjās*, *nyāsas*, *mudrās*, *mandalas*, *yāgas*, *homas* and mantric devices. For the *Shivakarmīs*, Shiva alone is supreme and is to be worshipped along with deities of *Shiva Brahmānda* or the Cosmos of Shiva. In their funerary rites the performer of the rites strikes at the head of the

deceased with a *jñāna khadga* or Sword of knowledge made of thirty-six blades of grass corresponding to the thirty-six *tattvas* of Shaiva cosmology. I have given full details of *Shivakarma antyeshti* rites in the book. However, many rituals mentioned in the Kashmiri Tantric texts are lost and there is no track of them.

The Vaishnavite Tantric cult of Pañcharātra with its own elaborate system of rituals must have also left an impact on the ritual behaviour of Kashmiri Hindus. The cult is believed to have flourished in Kashmir in early times and according to some had its birth there. These have been described in full detail in Pañcharātra texts like the *Jayākhyā* and *Ahīrabudhnya Samhitās*. Today we have only a vague reminder of Kashmir having been an important seat of the cult in the appellation *Pradyumna Pītha* given in BS to Hari Parbat. Pradyumna, it may be pointed out, is one of the four *vyūhas* or deities of the cult representing cosmic reality.

These then can be regarded as the main sources of inquiry about the ritual system of Kashmiri Hindus. Coming back to *samskāras* or life-cycle rituals, I have drawn attention to the fact that exigencies of circumstances brought about by the near total displacement of Kashmiri Pandits have greatly affected their ritualistic behaviour, contributing further to the cultural loss suffered by them due to the processes of modernization. Prolonged contact with Islam and Islamic way of life has done incalculable harm to their consciousness of their own traditions and religious practices, blunting their perceptive faculties. Of the sixteen standard *samskāras* they are today practically performing only the bare essential ones like *mekhal* or sacred thread investiture, *nethar* or marriage ceremony and *antyeshti* or funerary rites, and even that to the minimal extent.

A few words about the role of *samskāras* in the Hindu tradition become essential here. It is essential to note that *samskāras* consist of processes “by which the natural is transformed

into the cultural". The process of transformation starts with conception itself in the biological cycle of an individual which gets intimately related to that of another human being of the opposite sex, leading to a new human being coming into existence. The life cycle of the newly born person in turn gets closely intermixed with the life cycles of the parents for the rather long period of growing up and attaining maturity. It also gets enmeshed with the cycles of his siblings and other members of the family, as also their peers and marks the beginning of socialization with cultural values like love and sensitivity for each other's concerns and respect for the elders coming into play. The "ritualistic consecration" of marriage of two individuals starts it all. It is the symbolic character of the ceremonies performed at different stages of life right from the "biological moment" of conception to death that imbues these natural processes with the significance of a cultural dimension. The ritualistic procedures of *karmakānda* for transformation of the biological reality into cultural consciousness, is what lends Hindu *samskāras* with a meaningfulness and purposive character that raises human beings to a level beyond the purely biological existence of non-human beings. The subtle impressions that *samskāras* leave on mind set into motion processes that lead to acculturation and socialization.

Although the *Laugakshi Grihyasutra* gives details of the sixteen standards *samskāras*, Kashmiri Pandits have been done away with most of the prenatal ceremonies, including *dōd dyun* or curds ceremony which was performed till a few decades back. Among the post-natal ceremonies

too *jātakarma* or *shrānasōndar*, which consists of ritual bath given to the mother and child on or after the sixth day of birth, is hardly performed as a religious ritual. On the *shrānasōndar* day, it may be pointed out, ladies would assemble in the confinement room of the mother and pass lighted pieces of birch-bark around the head of the new born and all those who are present, shouting "*shokh ta panasund*". Though

some interpret these words as a distortion of "punahsantu" meaning "May you have more children", "*panasund*" may actually be remnant of a forgotten mantra or hymn. Though *kāhnethar* or the eleventh day purification rites corresponding to a blend of *jātakarma* and *nāmakarana* and *zarakāsay* or *mundana*, the first tonsure of the male child, and perhaps *annaprāshana* or ceremonial feeding of a new born child with solid food, are still performed by some, the precise dates prescribed in the sacred texts are no longer adhered to. Modifications have been introduced in the performance of other domestic rituals too due to circumstances. However, *mekhalor* the sacred thread investiture ceremony continues to be regarded as the most important initiation ritual prior to marriage for a boy. It is rather strange that the wearing the *mekhalā* or girdle to put the loin cloth in place, which is only a part of the ceremonies of *upanayana* or *yajñopavīta* has become the nomenclature of the whole *samskāra*. This is something that needs investigation. But one thing must be noted. Today it has become an outward sign of being a Hindu Brahmin, just *astshog* or the tuft of hair was sometime back.

The *upanayana samskāra* or sacred thread investiture ceremony as performed by Kashmiri Pandits seems to have been reduced to farce with a compact of as many as twenty four ceremonies right from *garbhādāna*, *kāhanethar*, *zarakāsay* and *vidyārambha* to *samāvartana* being rolled into one. But many of the indigenous ceremonies like *divagōn*, *nāriyan khārun*, *tēkytāl*, *vāridān* and *ādidarshun* have a great charm of their own which they have retained.. The *nāriyan khaārun* ceremony appears to resemble the *simāntonnayana* ceremony in some ways with husbands adorning the hair of their wives with the help of small mulberry twigs. Performed prior to *upanayana* of a boy or the marriage ceremony of a boy or a girl, *divagōn* is indeed a uniquely Kashmiri ceremony, colourful and exciting. On this occasion the to-be bride is decorated with bridal jewellery for the first time. This includes

the *dejihor*, the symbol of her married status, which is said to be designed as a stylized form of *shrīchakra*. The ornament is a late comer and shows the extent of the influence of the Shākta cult on Kashmiri Hindus. The word *divagōn* is probably derived from Sanskrit *devāgamana* and entails invoking the presence of gods – Ganesha and the *sapta mātirikās* – to bless the initiate or the boy or girl to be wedded. It begins with a ritual bath given to the initiate or would-be bride or bridegroom by four maidens holding a cloth over their heads and pouring oblations into the sacred fire. On the eastern wall drawing of *akalpavriksha* or the wish-fulfilling tree supposed to be the abode of the divinities in *Nandanavana* or the Garden of Paradise is made on a *shatchakra* base symbolizing Shakti is made for the invocation. The drawing is called *divtamūn* in Kashmiri meaning ‘column of the gods’.

The *yajñopavīta* ceremonies do not conclude with *samāvartana* or the ceremonial return of the *brhamachārī* after the supposed end of his student career. On the day following the sacred thread investiture, a small *homa* is performed to thank the gods for everything having passed off well.

Marriage, or *nethar* as it is called in Kashmiri, is regarded by the Kashmiri Hindus as the most important of all *samskāras* as it forms the cultural pivot around which the life of a person as a householder revolves and ensures continuation of the family and the race through the progeny. A Kashmiri Pandit marriage has all the core elements that constitute a Hindu wedding, but it also has several peculiarities that are distinctly Kashmiri, being a charming and yet a serene affair. Like *mekhal*, it too has *divagōn* as an essential constituent with Ganesha and the *sapta mātirikās* showering benedictions on the bride and the bridegroom. I would like to point to two ceremonies in particular as they are suggestive of historical and civilizational facts.. One is remembrance of Saraswati, the river and the goddess both. As the wedding is going on, a hymn is recited by the bride and the bridegroom in praise of the

River Saraswati on the banks of which the Brahmins of Kashmir are believed to have originally lived. The river, says the hymn, distributes its sweet waters as a mother distributes her wealth to the daughter:

*Āsyandamānā subhage nirgiribhyah Saraswati /
Māteva duhitribhyah kulyābhyo vibhajā vasu //*

[LGS Vol. I, 25 / 19]

Praising the goddess Saraswati, to whom Kashmiri Brahmins are so deeply devoted, the husband describes her as a gracious and beautiful lady of resplendent complexion, beautiful eyes and eyebrows, and prays to her to protect the lifelong companionship between him and his bride.

Another unique ceremony is about ceremonial entry of the *ganga vyas* or River Ganga personified as the bride’s personal friend soon after the *madhuparkaceremony*. This is mentioned in the *karmakānda* manual brought out by Pandit Keshav Bhatt Jyotshi. The role is played by a young girl from the bride’s side who acts as a confidant of hers. Nothing is known about the origin or purpose of this ceremony, but it appears that in ancient times the bride was actually led to the banks of a river by her female friends for a ritual bath. Later, during the Muslim rule, most probably during the Afghan period, this ritual must have been discontinued for fear of harassment. Supposed to be the embodiment of the holy river itself, the young girl is understood to function as a witness to the purity and sanctity of the marriage ceremonies.

There are some other uniquely interesting features of a Kashmiri Pandit wedding that need mentioning. These include ceremonies like *dvāra pūzā* and *posha pūzā*, the latter probably showing an influence of the *Shivakarmī* cult. After the bride’s father and the bridegroom’s father have greeted each other and the wedding guests have settled down to enjoy the wedding feast, the bride and the bridegroom are called to perform the *dvāra*

pūzā at the entrance gate of the bride's house. The bridegroom cannot enter the house without performing this ceremony at which the guardian deities of the gate are invoked and worshipped according to set procedure. They include Ganesha, Dharma, Adharma, Dehalī, Khinkhinī and gods of the ramparts of the Sumeru Mountain. The doors are taken to be the thresholds between the outside world and the consecrated space inside, offering passage into a new phase of life. It is considered essential to pay homage to these guardian deities of the door to ward off perils and dangers and bring in protection and auspiciousness. Before entrance the bridegroom and later the bride are made to stand on the consecrated cosmic circle called the *vyūg* and are identified with Shiva and Parvati or Lakshmi and Narayana. These very gods guarding the entrance, it may be pointed out, are also worshipped during *Grihapravesha* or the ceremony of entering a new house.

Posha Pūzā is the concluding and one of the most important ceremonies of Kashmiri Hindu marriage without which the nuptials are regarded as incomplete. The bride and the bridegroom are made to sit under a red canopy and worshipped with flowers as embodiments of Shiva and Parvati by their parents and close relatives. The benedictory verses recited on this occasion refer to the names of gods and goddesses, sages and seers, ancient warriors and famous kings and queens, pious mothers etc., perhaps to remind the couple of having ideal children like them, and wishing them a firm and loving relationship like ideal couples of Vedic and Puranic lore. The gods are invoked seeking their blessings so that they may obtain long life, learning, wealth, happiness and, of course, "many sons". The ceremony seems to have to do with *Shivakarma* ritual tradition.

As in the case of rituals of life, in performing rituals of death too Kashmiri Hindus are guided by notions of purity and impurity (*shaucha-ashaucha*) and auspicious-inauspicious (*shubha-ashubha*). But even more than that, they regard the ritual of cremation as a

"sacrifice" or an act of expiation through the medium of fire. This is because of a deep influence of Shaiva ritual and it has made the death rites among them very elaborate. It is the "final" sacrifice", according to the Shaivas, before the departed soul attains liberation or identification with the "supreme state of Shiva-hood". The funerary rituals of the sect known as *Shivakarmīs* are even longer and more complicated as they involve performance of a whole set of purification rituals even on the cremation ground to consume and destroy the karmic bonds of the deceased. The extreme shortage of performing priests after the exodus of Kashmir Pandits from Kashmir has made the situation indeed very difficult for those who want to perform the last rites of their deceased kin according to Kashmir rites as other priests are not acquainted at all with the procedures of the Kashmiri ritualistic system.

I have devoted a whole long chapter to Kashmiri *pūjā* rituals and festivals, analysing their structural aspects, history and also distinguishing characteristics. Rites are prescribed in religious texts for the *nitya* or daily worship and *naimittika* or acts of worship performed on sacred dates and special occasions. The latter include religious festivals, birthday celebrations, propitiation of planetary deities etc. in which elements from folk religion, mystic rites, cultic practices all combine and co-exist as constituents. Conceptualization of cosmic forces and symbolization of ceremonial acts and movements are significant aspects of Kashmiri *pūjā* rites, their basic ritual structure being related to the *shodasha upchāra pūjā* or the sixteen-step worship service which is the norm followed by Hindus everywhere, with of course some modifications and variations prompted by local factors. In its simplest form it starts with *āvāhana* or invocation to the deity to be present at the ritual setting, after which life is infused into the image by means of the prescribed mantras (*prāna pratishtā*) signifying that it is not the external image but the living deity present inside it who is being worshipped. After being invoked, the deity is

welcomed as a guest and offered seat (*āsana*), water for washing feet (*pādya*), libation of sacred water with rice grains, *Dūrvā* grass and flowers (*arghya*), water for rinsing the mouth (*āchamanīya*), bath for purification (*snāna*), lower and upper garment (*vastra* and *upavastra*), fragrant materials (*gandha*), flowers (*pushpa*), incense (*dhūpa*), lamp (*dīpa*), and last of all food (*naivedya*) which is partaken by the performer and the participants as the deity's gift of grace. The worshipper concludes the *pūjā* with *namaskāra* or salutation to the deity and then offering flowers and waving lamps (*ārātrikā*). With mantras he bids farewell to the deity (*visarjana*). In case of congregational or public *pūjā* performed in temples and sacred shrines, the concluding act is that of *pradakshinā* or circumambulation. The Kashmiri Hindus have, however, reduced it now to *pañchopchāra* and even further to what has been given the name of “*dhūpa-dīpa*”.

There are several other important ritual acts associated with *pūjā*, like purification of self, the ritual setting, and ritual objects, *prānāyāma*, recitation of the Gāyatrī mantra called *vyāhriti*, waving a five-wick oil or camphor lamp (*ratnadīpa*), holding a parasol (*chhatra*) over the image of the deity, blowing a conch (*shankha*) and singing hymns to the accompaniment of a ringing hand-bell (*ghantā*). This is what Richard Davis has termed as “the least common denominator of Pūjā as a form of Hindu worship”. It is within this broad structural and conceptual framework that regional variations, modifications and additions have emerged and given shape to peculiarities that can be distinctly identified as “Kashmiri”.

Kalsha pūjāna or worshipping or the water pot is an essential preliminary of Kashmiri *pūjā* ceremonies as it is believed to be the abode of all gods. According to Heather Elgood it conveys the idea of fullness and is “such a central element in and symbol of Hindu art that no ceremony can be performed without the installation of an auspicious vessel”. Consecrated

by *swastika* and *shrīchakram* marks made on it by vermilion, it is placed on an *ashtadala kamala* or eight-petal lotus drawn with rice flour or lime powder on the ground at the ritual site towards the east and on the left side of the *agnikunda*. Vishnu is supposed to occupy its mouth, Rudra its neck and Brahma its bottom. The group of *mātrikās* is known to reside in the middle part. Indra, Agni, Varuna, Vāyu and Yama all reside inside it. The *kalasha* also represents the ten directions along with their presiding deities. All the oceans and the earth with its even continents rest in the interior part of it. The Vedas – Rig, Yajus, Sāma, and Atharva, with all their auxiliary texts assemble in the water pot:

Kalashasya mukhe Vishnuh kanthe Rudrah samasthitah / mūle tatra sthito Brahmā madhye matriganah smritāh / kukshau tu sāgrāh sarvesaptdvīpā vasundharā / Rīgvedo tha Yajurvedah Sāmavedo hy' Atharvanah / angaishcha sahitāh sarve kalashantu samāshritāh //

Kalasha pūjā begins with the hymn portraying the Vedas as the wish-fulfilling tree and praying to it for protection.

There are special procedures for special *pūjās* as, for instance, those associated with festivals. Linked with civilizational memory, which they help to enact, festivals and celebrations can be described as cultural events internalized by people to such an extent that they feel compelled to participate in them as they find their identity in doing so.

An interesting fact about some Kashmiri Hindu festivals that I have tried to investigate is that their dates fall one or two days earlier than the day on which they are celebrated in the rest of the country. Shivaratri and Janmashtami are two examples of such festivals. As for Shivaratri, the most important of Kashmiri Pandit festivals, it is celebrated on *tryodashī* or thirteenth day of the dark half of the month of Phalguna and not on *chaturdashī* as in the rest of India. The celebrations actually extend from

the *pratipadā* or the first day to *amāvasyā* or the last day of the dark fortnight or even beyond to the tenth day of the bright half. Digging into the pages of some forgotten Tantric texts, I have excavated the story of the *Jwālālinga* about the origin of the festival. Describing the whole festival in all its details and symbolism, I have explained that these texts term Shivaratri as *Bhairavotsava* as on this occasion Bhairava and Bhairavi are to be propitiated through Tantric worship. According to the story, Svachhandanatha Bhairava, a five- faced form of Shiva, appeared as a *Jwālālinga* or a column of fire at *pradoshakāla* or the dusk of early night on *trayodashī*. Failing to find the beginning or end of the *linga*, Vatuka Bhairava, the principal deity of the *pūjā*, and Ram Bhairava sing its praises while Shakti, whose mind -born sons they were, merges into it. The two emerged, one after the other, with all their weaponry from two pitchers filled with water when the Great Goddess cast her glances into them. She assured Vatuka that he will essentially receive worship first on the *trayodashī*. This is perhaps the reason that Vatuka is worshipped in the form of a pitcher filled with water into which walnuts are kept to soak and later distributed *asnaivedya*. Rāma Bhairava or Raman Bhairava also has a role to play on the conclusion of Shivaratri celebrations. He is the “Rām Bror” who knocks at the door and promises to bring happiness and prosperity to women of the celebrating family. It is sad that this beautiful piece of drama has been forgotten and Ram Bror is regarded to be a benign cat and not Rāma Bhairava, the Devi’s mind-born son.

Consecrated an iconic pottery is an important part of Shivaratri *pūjā* – a unique feature of it. Apart from the earthen pitcher representing Vatuka Bhairava, special hand-moulded vessels of various shapes and sizes believed to be charged with spiritual power and representing the main deities are worshipped during the *pūjā*. These include a cone-shaped clay *linga* called *Sanipōtul* and an open-mouthed vessel having three parts called *Vāgur*. Ridiculous etymology of both

these images have been floated, but the *sanipōtul* actually represents five-faced Shiva (Svachhandanāth Bhairava?) on which water is sprinkled for *abhisheka*. The etymology of *Vāgur* is more confusing. Could it be derived from Vyāghreshvar – probably the name of a Bhairava? Whatever the case may be these aniconic vessels are a very interesting and fascinating aspect of Shivaratri *pūjā* in Kashmir and decoding its mystery is very challenging job.

It may sound to be a tall claim but the manner in which I have described most of the major festivals of Kashmiri Hindus together with their peculiarities and symbolism, seems to have some lesser known facts concerning them to light. Besides Herath or Shivaratri these festivals include *Navreh*, *Jyeshtha Ashtami*, *Khetsi Mavas*, *Pan*, *Tiky Tsoram* and several others. The fact is that they reveal Kashmiri Hindus as people who celebrated life and tried to live in perfect harmony with their beautiful natural environs, finding glimpses of divinity in its phenomena. Their all-inclusive philosophy of Shaiva monism rejects the otherness of God and emphasizes the oneness of Man, God and World. It is sad, however, that some *pūjās* that were quite popular in Kashmir only a few decades back are now completely forgotten. And though in my study, I have tried to record for the religious historian facts of their history and their ritualistic aspects as far as I could, I feel sad that they are no longer being performed. One of these was the *Pañchāyatana Pūjā*, which involved worshipping the five major deities of the Hindu pantheon – Vishnu, Shiva, Devi (Durga), Ganesha and Surya – with the image of the favourite deity (*ishta devatā*) of the worshipper placed in the centre and of the others at four corners in the temple or the *thokur kuth*. Forgotten also is the *Parthiveshvara pūjā*, which isat once a folk art and a ritual. It consists of making an instant Shivalinga of clay, together with images of Kumara, Ganapati, Uma and the eleven Rudras. The *linga* and other images were made artistically of clay obtained from a *devasthāna* or place of worship, the

Shankracharya Hill being a popular place for Pandits of Srinagar to dig for it. As the clay images could be easily immersed into the river after the worship, *Parthiveshvara pūjā* probably became quite popular in Kashmir during the Muslim rule when fear of persecution made visiting temples for congregational worship a risk.

Ritual art compliments religious practices as a means to express the invisible in terms of the visible. Though not exactly driven by aesthetic impulse, this art has been an integral part of the religious life of Kashmiri Hindus. To put it in the words of Heather Elgood, the role of Hindu religious art is to “act as a threshold between the worlds of gods and men”. For the Kashmiri Hindus too ritual art forms serve many purposes. Some of them serve as an aid to meditation, while some are believed to have the potential of driving away evil forces and protecting from calamity and misfortune. Many of them are associated with auspiciousness and well-being which they are supposed to attract through their magical power. Yet many such art forms have disappeared or are on the verge of disappearing – a sad commentary on a community which claims to be concerned about preserving its traditions. In fact my attempt to explore the function, meaning and symbolism of these dying folk art forms was a venture no art historian had undertaken so far. I had dared to open a systematic line of inquiry into a totally uncharted area. The field I surveyed was indeed vast in range, covering *Gora Tray*, *Vyūg*, *Krūl*, *Hāramandul*, *Krūla Pachh*, *Dīvtamūn*, *Tēky Tāl*, *Chittāvāsa*, *Shrīchakra*, aniconic pottery used in Shivaratri worship, drawings related to several life-cycle rituals and much more. The total indifference and disinterestedness displayed towards these by Kashmiri Pandits, a people whose ancestors gave shape to the building blocks of Indian aesthetics, shocked me. The way beautiful art forms like *Gora Tray* executed freehand by priest artists and women were allowed to die – people would paste them on their window panes to block blasts of cold air from entering the room during winter months -- tells an

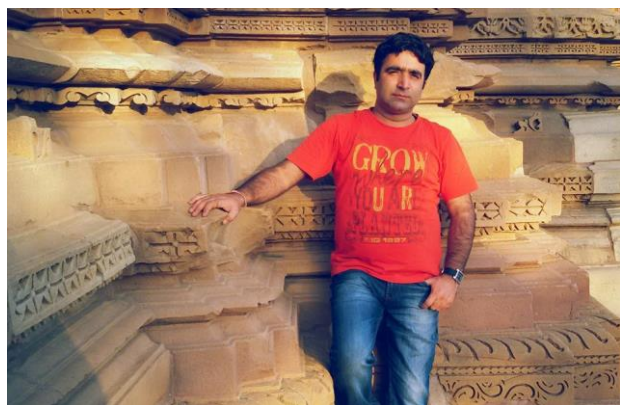
extremely sad and painful story. *Gora Tray* has – the scroll paintings with the image of Saraswati and a hymn to her at the centre which used to delight the hearts of Kashmiri Pandit children only few decades back -- has vanished without a trace. It has been allowed to die and disappear due to sheer indifference and deadening of aesthetical sensibilities. Years back I went from town to town, village to village, person to person to find one single surviving specimen, but without any success. The *Krūl Pachh* and almanac paintings have met the same fate. The *Vyūg*, a descendant of the *bhūmishobhā* of the Nilamata Purana, is still there because it is still thought essential to make the bridegroom and the bride stand on it at weddings, but in what a grotesque and crude form. The same is the case with *Krūl*, the floral designs painted on the entrance door at the time of a marriage or Yajñopavit ceremony. The *Hāramandul* – a representation of the Sun god drawn on the floor-- is since gone. The *Tēky Tāl* or patterns of *shrīchakra* and *bindu* is in equally bad shape. I undertook to note some peculiarities of this wonder art as I was deeply fascinated by the inherent symbolism of the shapes and configurations of these ritual drawings with the square standing for consecrated space and the circle easily identifiable with “the cyclical flow of time”.

I hope it will be appreciated that in my study I have desperately tried to capture the feel of a culture lived – a way of life once vibrant but now in the last throes of its existence. What can be more tragic than that the deeply painful long suffering Hindus of Kashmir should have lost the even the feeling of a cultural loss that should have stunned them. They have lost their land, they are about to lose their language and if they lose their rituals also, they could well lose their selfhood even for rituals are symbols of identity. The danger of deracination looming large over them is real and terrible. I think Prof. Fotedar will bear me out that as we surveyed the situation on the ground to enable me to make a headway regarding my project on rituals, we found it to be appalling. Amnesia seemed to

threaten to take over everything. I hope my work on the rites and rituals of Kashmiri Brahmins will rekindle the flame of desire in them to know their real image and protect it from being wiped out.

(Dr. S.S Toshkhani is a poet, linguist, writer and a thinker. He has contributed substantially to Kashmiri heritage and carried out modern research in various fields of Kashmiri literature, history, religion, art and social sciences)





Spiritual orphans: Is it the end of Kashmiri Shaiva lineage ?

Neeraj Santoshi Khar

Has the lineage of Shaiva Masters, especially in the context of oral tradition and guru shishya parampara, that existed in the Himalayan valley of Kashmir for over a millennia, ended? Was Swami Lakshman joo last in the lineage? Is Shaiva tradition on decline or dying in the land of its birth? Is observing some festivals and rituals giving us a false feeling of being Shaivites? Are we being hypocrites who keep on harping about Shaiva roots and ignore the fact that Shaiva traditions are fading from the Kashmiri ethos?

If renowned physicists are discovering the parallels between Spanda and quantum physics, why our leaders and scholars have failed to teach us even the simple Shaiva traditions and their significance in the modern idiom. Do they really know or understand it themselves. How many of them would have read all the volumes of Abhinavgupta's masterpiece Tantraloka, forget about understanding it and teaching it.

It pains me that our elders have failed in passing on the teachings and the essence. Our generation is like potted plants lying on dusty staircases of high rise buildings, content with our stunted and claustrophobic potted roots. Phony words and claims of great Shaivist heritage are no substitute for the real transmission, for real earthy touch.

In this sense, I feel like a spiritual orphan, who is trying to fathom the sea of Shaivism on his own with

few paper boats (books, cyberworld) and limited knowledge. Nietzsche says somewhere ``One repays a teacher badly if one always remains nothing but a pupil''. Given the stature of Shaiva Masters like Abhinavgupta's, Vasugupta or Swami Ram, we have really been very bad repayers.

Our generation watches the rituals and traditions of our community in exile with great amusement, unaware of their underlying spiritual significance. The fact is that elaborate rituals are now skipped on most occasions and short cuts are being taken- be it in rituals related to birth, death, birthdays or marriages. Gloss has overtaken most of our functions, while the spiritual side has taken a backseat. It seems that we are slowly moving towards a collective spiritual amnesia.

The realization of this spiritual blackhole dawned on me, when few years back I met world famous authority on Tantra and Kashmiri Shaivism, Mark Dyczkowski, who originally hails from Russia, in Jammu. It was a dream come true, an encounter that exposed my ignorance about the real significance of Shaivism and my superficial academic understanding of it.



I had always deeply desired to see a real Shaiva master and talk with him or her or at least be face to face with a real scholar who knows the secrets of Shaiva tradition of Kashmir. I hardly know of any living Kashmiri who can be said to be a living Shaiva Master or a real scholar who knows the mysteries of Shaivism. May be there are secret Masters, but almost no one is in the public domain who can be given the credit for taking the Shaivist lineage forward.

Dyczkowski was in Jammu to attend a conference.

When I came to know about it, I was very excited. After few enquires that day, I came to know he was in the famous Raghunath Sanskrit Library, looking for some ancient texts. I was not aware where the famous Library, whose catalogue of nearly 6000 rare Sanskrit texts was prepared by Sir Aurel Stein himself in 1894, was.

I knew it was somewhere near the Raghunath temple. After half an hour of search and directions from the local shopkeepers, I reached the Library. I made a mental map of questions in English, which I had to ask. For me, Dyczkowski was a Russian scholar, who had studied Shaivism. A foreign scholar. I had imagined him as a high brow scholar, with an air of aloofness and absentmindedness, who would dish out replies in Hinglish accent. But when I saw him, I was taken aback. He was antithesis of everything that I had imagined about him. He was sitting comfortably in a chair in front of the Library. Basking in winter sun and conversing with scholar employee of the Library, he was eating groundnuts with a laidback approach, his demeanour never suggesting that he was the man who wrote the famous Doctrine of Vibration. Wearing a casual kameez payijama, with silky white beard and a shining face, he seemed a rishi from some ancient era. His eyes had the freshness of wonder and a soft glint of a child. He spoke in fluent Hindi, surprising me further. And I switched over to Hindi as well, loving his gentle sprinkling of Sanskrit shalokas intermittently.

After introducing myself, I started asking him general questions, trying to cover-up my ignorance of the higher topics of which he was a master. When I told him, that even now there are no institutions or research centres dedicated to the study of Shaivism in the land of its birth, he was surprised, but didn't show much emotion. He told me that it was indeed surprising that while in many parts of the world, hundreds of institutions and scholars are dedicatedly researching various facets of Kashmiri Shaivism and the works of various Shaiva masters like Abhinavgupta, Vasugupta, Anandvardhan, Bhatta Kalatta are being researched upon, it is a surprise that there is no serious institution in the birthland.

.
When I asked him how he was initiated into the

mysteries of Shaivism, looking far into the distance, as if looking at the fast collage of the past events, he recalled that it was great Shaiva master Swami Lakshaman joo who had initiated him in 1976. Even after studying different aspects of Shaivism for the last four decades, I could see the reverence in his eyes for his Master.

Then suddenly, as if hinting that my earlier question was not that important or foolish, he said, ``To understand the mysteries of Shaivism, one needs grace of Lord Shiva and then dedicated efforts in the right direction``.

As if questioning my stress on books and institutions, Mark said with a childlike innocence, ``If the grace of Shiva is there , then only the spark will aflame your soul, then only access to the teachings of Shaivism through different mediums like books, CDs, audio cassettes, book exhibitions, workshops, seminars and lectures of scholars will help and mature your recognition`` .

On his relations with the Ishwar ashram, the ashram of Swami Lakshaman joo, he said that he is not much in touch,...hinting subtly that how he got disillusioned with the ashram affairs after the departure of the Master.

That day I felt I had met a person, who has transcended the scholarship of Shaivism and was now moving on the higher paths as a seeker. His life is evident of his dedication towards understanding the mysteries of Shaivist tantra. He has devoted his whole life to the study, collation, edition, translation and interpretation of manuscripts of the Shaiva and Kaula Tantra. Dyczkowski, who lives and works in Benares is a Masters in Philosophy and Indian Religion from Benares Hindu University and has studied Sanskrit grammar and literature with Pandit Ambikadatta Upadhyaya. After graduating from BHU, he went to England, finished his doctorate in 1980 at Oxford University where he studied under the eminent Prof Alexis Sanderson, on the Spanda School of Kashmiri Shaivism. In 1980 he came back to Benares and

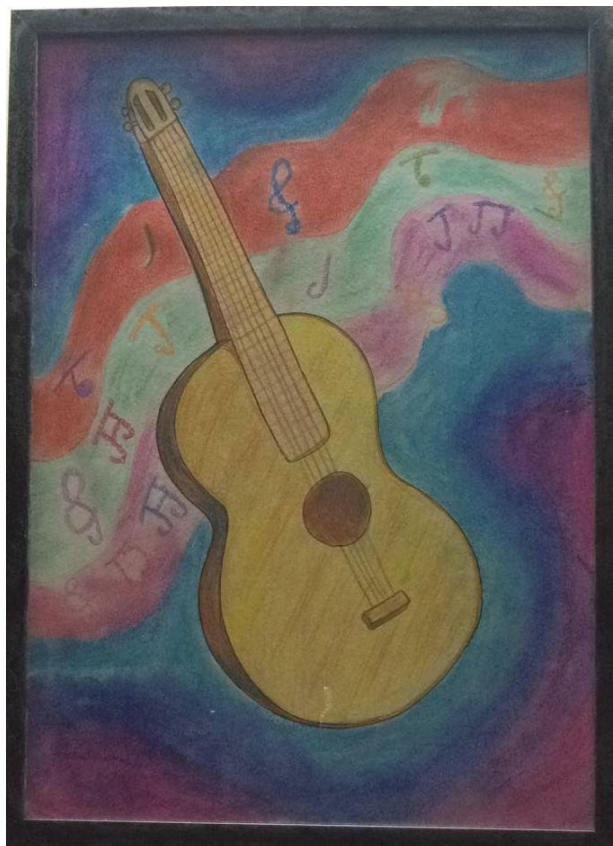
started his research work.

This man who is author of The Aphorisms of Siva, The Stanzas on Vibration, 14 volume work on the Kubajika tantra, had no scholarly air about his being. He seemed a simple Shaiva bhakt to me, a modern day rishi . His simple demeanour, seemed to defy the fact that he is arguably the most original and wide-ranging scholar of Hindu Tantra alive today. As a community, I feel ashamed that we don't invite him in our functions, for lectures, discourses, workshops for young or for felicitating him. Most of our leaders are busy in petty organizational politics, factionism and mini power struggles.

If this generation fails to carry forward the Shaiva traditions and the lineage, a day will come when all that will be left will be a swelled fan list on Shaivism groups on social sites like facebook and hollow claims of our great Shaiva heritage. The real touch of a master, a real seeker is missing somewhere....words and clicks help to a certain level...but primarily one needs grace, guidance and guru....

That day when I accompanied Mark Dyczkowski back to his university guestroom , where he was staying, in an auto-rickshaw, I felt his silent grace and love.....it was wordless....when we departed....he just smiled with his eyes beaming with childlike wonder....that day I felt as if all Shaiva masters of last one millennia were smiling through him.... I recognized in his eyes a somewhat similar expression that I had once seen as a kid in the compassionate eyes of Swami Lakshaman joo, while he blessed me and gave me handfuls of prasad at his Ishwar Ashram in Kashmir...

(Neeraj Santoshi Khar is a journalist with Hindustan Times and is an avid reader and seeker of the philosophical knowledge)



Creative Impulse in Pratyabhijna Philosophy with a reference to Pratyabhijnahrdayam of Ksemaraja

Geetika Kaw Kher

Aestheticization of philosophy frees it from the burden of extensive intellectualization and also ensures the dawning of true knowledge and feeling of pleasure evoked by such a dawning. True knowledge only dawns when knowledge takes root not in our minds but in our hearts. The universal appeal of Pratyabhijna philosophy is due to the fact that it blends both rational and emotional side of a person hence venturing into an array of subjects comprising metaphysics, epistemology, aesthetics and philosophy.

The word ‘Pratyabhijna’ means recognition of one’s essential nature and the entire gamut of literature dealing with the theme is meant to bring home the fact that it is possible to realize one’s own Sivahood.

Two aspects of Parama Siva, **Visvotirna** and **Visvamaya** are accepted in Pratyabhijna.

Visvotirna form of Siva has infinite powers and contains everything inside him in the form of a seed but to manifest into many Param Siva has to assume a dynamic form which is known as Visvamaya Shiva.

“अस्यास्यदेकरूपेण वपुषा चेन्महेश्वरः ।
महेश्वरत्वं संवित्त्वं तदत्यक्ष्यद् घटादिवत् ॥”

(Tantraloka III.100)

“If the highest reality did not manifest in infinite variety but remained cooped up within its solid singleness it would neither be the highest power nor Consciousness, but something like a jar”

Visvamaya aspect is the creative aspect of Param Siva. It is aesthetically expressed as a desire of a creator to procreate and multiply. The entire universe lies as a potency in the heart of supreme like a banyan tree lies as a potency in its seed. This analogy from Tantraloka reminds of the similar example given by Aristotle of the acorn and the oak tree and how the blue print of an oak tree lies hidden in the form of an acorn. The essential form of anything defines what it is, and provides the driving force for that thing's existence and development. Everything strives to

"grow into" its form, and the form defines what the thing can potentially become.

When Siva desires to create he has to summon **Sakti** or become **Jnana-Kriya** rupa to descend. The Sakti of Parama Shiva is seen as **Citi**

The concept is expressed in a poetic manner in the second verse from **PratyabhijnaHridayam**, a digest on the system prepared by Ksemaraja, a student of Abhinavagupta

स्वेच्छया स्वभित्तौ दिश्वमुन्मीलयति ॥ २ ॥

‘By the power of her own will, ‘Citi’ unfolds the universe upon her own screen. That is she unfolds the tattvas from Sadasiva to Prithvi ‘like a city in a mirror which though non different from it appears as different’ because it is a mirror image. This creative play termed as ‘lila’ is often celebrated in artistic creations, visual and verbal both. The space that manifested universe occupies in the scheme of Pratyabhijna is the mirror space, mysterious and real at the same time.

Mirror space though it reflects our space is not continuous with it. A concept which has fascinated visual artists as well as writers all the time. Use of mirror can be seen widely as a literary and artistic device and also as a spiritual medium. Eg. ‘**to see yourself in the mirror of your friend**’ is a phrase often used by Maulana Rumi in his Masnawi...

Mirror space is construed as a space which can make us escape our limited reality..We find the metaphor extensively used in Lewis Carroll’s ‘Alice in wonderland’ and in recent works by the Japanese author Haruki Murakami where you often find the character looking in the mirror and leaving behind his/her reflection.and this reflection being much more pervasive and free than the protagonist..Murakami borrows these ideas from **Shinto mysticism** which again focuses on possibility of entering the other realms hence transcending the boundaries of kala and niyati.

The continuous search for oneness is hampered by the veil of Maya Shakti which binds us to various malas through the coverings (kanchukas)

चिद्वत्तच्छवित्संकोचात् मलावृतः संसारी ॥ ६ ॥

When the highest reality whose very essence is consciousness conceals by his His free will pervasion of non duality and assumes duality then his will and other powers though essentially unlimited assume limitation. Soul is covered with Mala so the all-pervading knowledge reduces to the knowledge of few things.

The ultimate creative play gets translated into individual or group creativity in human beings. Art provides a powerful medium to transcend this physical world. By submitting to ‘Willful Suspension of Disbelief’, a concept attributed to Coleridge there is a chance to escape into the imaginary world created by the artist. Carl Jung proposes that “ True art is something supra-personal’ a force which has escaped from the limitations of the personal and has soared beyond the personal concerns of its creator”

Thus creativity is a tool to understand oneself. An urge to create is seeking our ultimate creative self through art and to de-individualize the emotions felt, so that they are in their purest form able to create a universal experience. The idea of ‘**Sadharanikaran**’ or universalization of emotions is one of the key concepts of Abhinavagupta’s aesthetic thought . To create is to transcend the boundaries of limited existence by introverting the senses. Hence art is considered as a sadhana which has power to de-individualize not only the creator but the spectator/reader/ too.

No wonder stalwarts like Bharata, Bhatta Kallata, Sri Sankuka and Abhinavagupta have given so much importance to aesthetic theories The concept of **Camatkara** which was later developed and elaborated extensively by Abhinavagupta grew out of this branch of knowledge raising the status of art to that of creation of the universe and hence considering entire creative process as a universal play. Abhinavagupta accepted Bhatta Nayaka’s view that the aesthetic and the mystic experiences spring from the same source and the bliss we derive from them is a state of independence from all extraneous factors.





Kailash Mansarovar Yatra- The ultimate pilgrimage

Sunder Shridhar

SunThe Second part of this travelogue is available at <http://www.yogtantragama.org/yta-5-issue-7th-april-final.pdf>

Part 3- The Saga of ‘Saga’ and onwards to Mansarovar



The early morning of 21st August turned out to be overcast and grey. Our spirits however were bright and soaring. This was, of course, THE most awaited part of the trip. We were going to be in the Presence of Mount Kailash!

We were to begin our trek to Kailash from Darchen. Presumably it was called Darshan earlier, as Darshan means vision or View and one can get a good view of the holy Mount on a sunny day from here. As we were travelling in a caravan of vans to Darchen from

Mansarovar, I noticed snow all along the route. A tiny voice whispered within- God, let the weather be ok for all of us to trek the whole way to His Darshan. At Darchen, those who needed them, were given ponies and porters and walking sticks based on the decision of the Swamis travelling with us.

The Swamis advised us to walk with reverence... as if we were walking on the body of Shiva Himself and to chant **ShivaShamBho** with each consecutive step and then began the 15 Km long trek to Dhirapuk. We were grouped in teams of 4. I was with another male yatri and two other ladies. Soon, I was walking only with the ladies as they were having difficulty walking and would take frequent breaks. I decided that no matter what, I would be with them and help them make it, even if it took me longer than I would have normally taken. My own physical preparation of 5 months of Yoga before the trip came in handy as I did not really feel the strain of walking along.

The views along the trek were surreal- high cliffs on both sides with waterfalls from impossible heights. The Lha Chu river, also believed to be the Ganga by some, gushed and roared along the trek route. There were brightly colored Tibetan Prayer flags all around and a few monasteries and temples in the cliffs far away. The Tibetan pilgrims who followed the Bon Po religion, were able to do the trek with much more ease than us who were not used to the rarefied air at this height. Many of them made the entire circumambulation of the Mount by prostrating fully!

We saw all the seasons in the course of the trek. The weather Gods blessed us, though ! Although, it had snowed the previous night, the weather cleared up shortly after we started trekking and the trek was done amidst light drizzles and perfect sunshine. Several of the Yatris had difficulty in breathing, and Oxygen cylinders were provided to them. So, while some made the trek in 4 hours, I and my group took almost double the time, with the frequent breaks that we took to rest. It is not a very steep trek, but the low oxygen levels makes one tired easily and one needs to take frequent breaks. From Darchen to Dhirapuk, is a slow ascent of 1500 feet with no steep climbs. But from Dhirapuk to Darchen, if one goes the Parikrama route, then one crosses the Dolma La pass, which is at 19200 feet and is most often covered deeply in snow. Isha Sacred Walks does only half a parikrama. Sadhguru, very aptly gives the following reasons for this:



- Physically, very few of us are capable of crossing this pass.
- Once out of Dhirapuk, one loses sight of Kailash and sees Him only when one is back at Darchen
- It is more important to spend time in His presence and meditate rather than walk around, panting.
- A very specific Yogic process is performed in front of the Holy Mount, which is intense and gives the same benefits as a full Parikrama.

The previous day, when asked by someone at Mansarovar, if Sadhguru would accompany the group to Kailash, He had said with a laugh, "Of course, I will be there with you." which brought a smile on everyone's lips. True to His words, even though physically absent, Sadhguru's Grace was Evident throughout the trek.

Our porters would scamper ahead of us with the luggage at great speed and then wait for us to catch up. Although they knew only Tibetan, they would keep making gestures for us to give them more money !

After about 7 hours, the signboard of Shishapangma Hotel (more like a dormitory- but quite comfortable), was visible and about a km away, was the dormitory itself. One of the ladies just then gave up and sat down saying she could not make it. I tried to tell her.. hey we are almost there... we can see our accommodation... but to no avail. There was no other alternative.. I physically supported her and made her walk all the way to the dormitory. Only as I was very close to the

dormitory, did the North face of Mount Kailash become visible..



The fog lifted and there He was in all His massive Glory! The moment is etched in my mind because tears streamed and my eyes were blurring. Soon it fogged up again and only the lower part of the mountain was visible.

Then the tiredness started showing up in me and the beds and the quilts were invitingly warm. After a rest , as we came out for food, again the amazing moonlit view of the mountain enthralled me. The 1 night and 2 days spent at Dhirapuk were memorable as we got to see Him in various hues and forms- sunny and clear, foggy, rainy and so on. The special Yogic process done by the Swamis, with the group facing Mount Kailash, was a different experience in itself, taking the energies to a wonderful high. Another experience when I felt truly blessed was being asked by one of the Swamis to chant the hymn - ' Ya Devi Sarva bhuteshu' - for the Divine mother, amidst the entire gathering in the presence of the blessed mountain. Whenever I could, I took the opportunity to sit in a meditative posture and experience His Grace while chanting various Mantras.

That night, medical screening went on till around 12:30, and decisions were taken to send some people back by ambulance. Quite a few people had succumbed to the low pressure and unavailability of oxygen. The doctor's room was occupied with people gasping in Gamow bags or through oxygen masks. Altitude sickness can manifest in many different ways and people who were not careful with their chronic conditions, suddenly had a spike. One elderly pilgrim's blood sugar shot up to 480 and had to be given insulin.

The sherpas and Tibetan guides had told us that around 40000 pilgrims visit Kailash every year and that around 4000 don't go back. This was scary. But as

Sadhguru had promised, he did not intend to leave any one of us behind. The arrangements were wonderful and all of us survived, though some did have to return earlier and by faster means.

The return trek was faster as many of us had gotten used to the climate and the air pressure by then. We collected water flowing down in streams from the Kailash in bottles to take back home.

We crossed Chokhu Gompa, made famous by Swami Rama's disciple Pandit Rajmani Tigunait, in his book, "At the eleventh hour". According to Swami Rama, this monastery is built around an ancient cave which was the meditation centre for Sanat Kumara and his brothers. Swami Rama's favourite mantra was the Gayatri. In his memory and a mark of respect to all the masters of the Himalayan tradition, we stood facing the monastery and recited the Gayatri for some time.

The last point was YamaDwar. At this point, we turned back towards the trekking path and prayed to Him, asking His pardon for all sins committed knowingly or unknowingly.

The one feeling that filled our hearts was gratitude- to our gurus whose blessings gave us the desire to reach Him. We were filled with thankfulness to the Lord for His grace and His darshan.



We went on to the bus, and then to Manasarovar for a quick lunch. It was a long haul to Saga and again from there to Zhangmu. The journey was punctuated with a lot of activity in the buses, which were inspired by Swamijis. So antakshari, 20 questions, Queen of Sheba needs, etc. kept us busy during this interminable journey back.

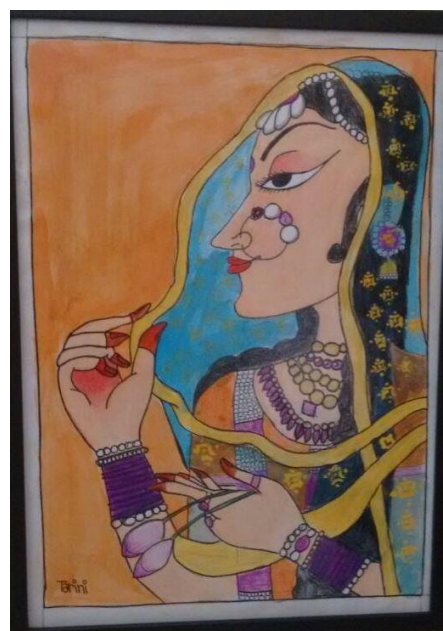
At the Hotel back in Kathmandu, we ended the entire trip with a lovely skit put together by some of the

creative devotees. The skit had all of us holding our stomachs in laughter. Then came the grand dinner and good byes.

We all parted ways but thanks to Sadhguru and Swamijis, we had become a family of people who had vowed to take a bit of Kailash home and transform ourselves.

Om Namah Shivaya!

(Sunder Shridhar is an engineer and currently is working as a Project Manager at Unisys Corp, Bangalore)

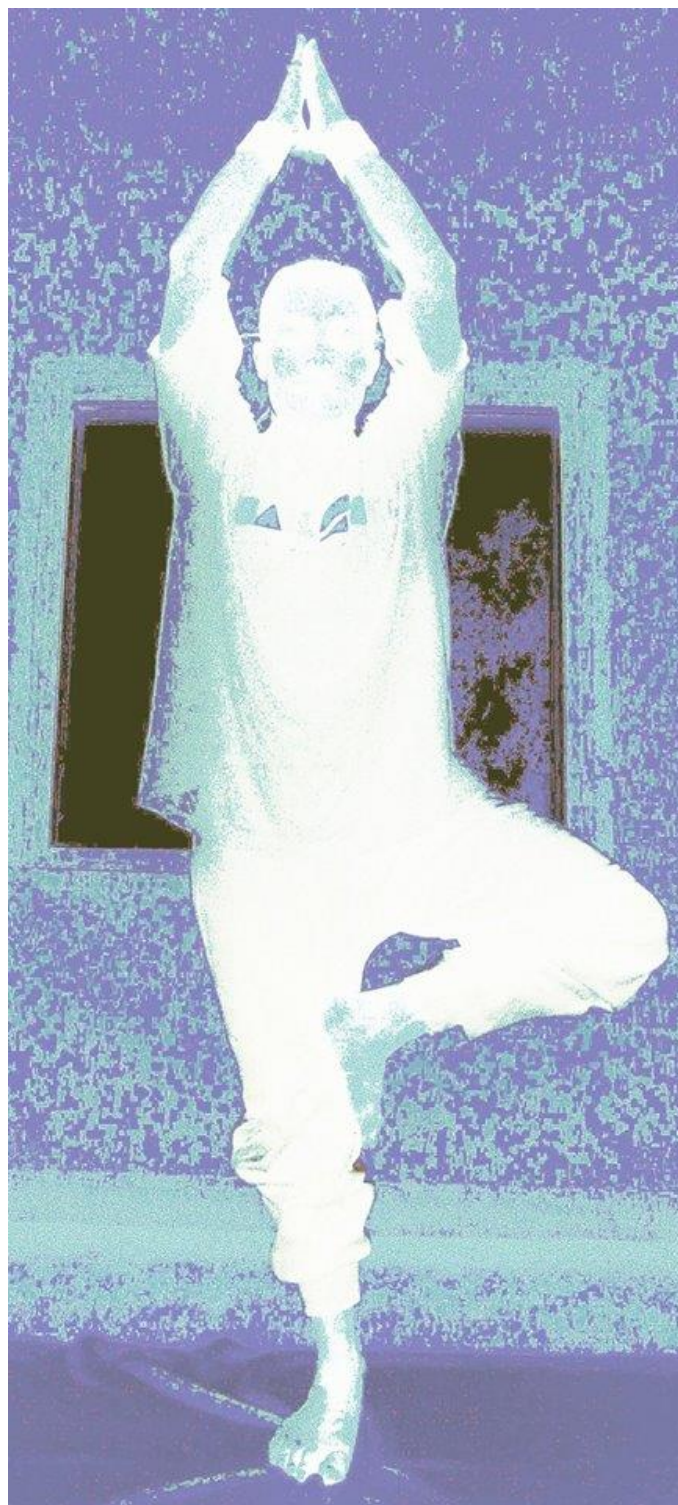




A passage from my recent scribble in the manuscript - "Thoughts perform Actions" –

Suva

We are accustomed to assume our previous birth state and presume the aftermath of death, involving the circumstantial situation of our physical plane. Our physical plane is a labour force run by the mental faculty. This functioning body is a managing booth of inevitable space, time and mannerisms of happening activities. A lot happens or remains static in the circumnavigation of existential paradigm. Our journey relies quite much on this constitution in rotundity. Besides such speculations, we are interwoven in the phenomena of mental and physical properties that which links us to the anatomy of life, that reconsiders a shared space amidst this governing body. When we look into what we know as health, in most cases the effect and cause revolves around these circuits of connection. As humans we do not have access to the ground level in recalling the past or previous life cycle or to reveal the impact-oriented post of future dynamics. So that brings us to the mid ways which we know as present. Therefore we, generally keep aside our sub-conscious, unconscious and supra-conscious catalog, to dust out only our present consciousness. Our being in this consciousness relates to the "gift" of life, often in a transitory phase of pleasant and unpleasant catharsis. This depends on the umbrella-form of our circumstance that triggers our modes, methods, means and mannerisms. We therefore get enlisted as passengers in the vehicle of reaction.



(Suva is a freelance performance artist and a musician based in Finland. Academically trained in sculpture he now teaches Yoga and acoustic drumming and is involved in creating experimental music)



YOGTANTRAGAMA
ISSN NO: 2454-888X



Published by : Rashneek Kher, 901-902, Iris Tower,
Faridabad, Haryana, 121010 for YTA Inc.

E-mail: swamiparanand@gmail.com

Logo: Manik Chawla

Paintings by Tarini Kher

